Solace

A Jellyfish & Giants project

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Summary

In this peaceful puzzle strategy game, players build a thriving colony of spacefaring woodland Nomes. As the Nome Architect, players place tiles to grow a network of energy-gathering root systems, adjusting their terrain each turn to meet changing goals throughout the game.

Introduction

Solace is a cosy puzzle strategy game where players build an interlocking network of roots, using terrain tiles to build their Nomes a new home.

As the Nome Architect, players conjure and place tiles of land to grow the sprawling root system of the World Tree. The expanding network of roots generates the energy needed to turn this temporary shelter into a vibrant community. Each turn, players search for the optimal tile layout in order to better support life above the ground.

The game is designed for players who enjoy intuitive, satisfying puzzle mechanics in a low-stress environment, free from time pressure and with the flexibility to fix mistakes. These players are likely to have enjoyed other "cosy-strategic" games like *Dorfromantik* (Toukana Interactive, 28 Apr, 2022), *ISLANDERS* (Coatsink, 4 Apr, 2019), *Mini Motorways* (Dinosaur Polo Club, 21 Jul, 2021).

Solace will be developed in Unreal Engine, targeting an initial PC release on Steam. Its monetization model will be a premium release title for a RRP of NZD$14.99.

Image 1. Initial concept art for Solace

Project Pillars

Agency

Preliminary playtests using paper prototypes revealed that a feeling of agency is a key factor in the enjoyment players derive from the game. In order to maximise satisfaction, players need to feel that they are impacting outcomes rather than relying on luck. Players need to believe that they can improve their skills over subsequent runs, and to that end the game must incentivise & reward strategic choices and displays of skill in decision-making during each round.

Managing Overlapping Objectives

In order to create a comprehensive experience for players with varying levels of skill and experience, the puzzle needs to offer rewarding gameplay with a low skill floor and high skill ceiling. This game layers simple mechanics with competing and complementary objectives in order to create layers of complexity for players.

The puzzle elements must be simple to interact with but have sufficient complexity in the interplay of objectives to remain challenging and engaging across subsequent plays for players as their skill and experience increases.

Challenge Without Conflict

In order to appeal to conflict-averse casual players, the game needs to avoid using combat or direct conflict in order to drive the gameplay and narrative.
The game will avoid the player engaging in direct conflict or causing conscious harm to other beings, and will instead focus on other themes to create an engaging experience, such as:

- Cultivation
- Protection
- Growth

Image 2: The above images are initial concept art for Nome characters

Narrative

The Nomes have arrived in the area of space where they plan to build a new home. Unfortunately, the Golden Seed that acts as the heart of their World Tree and the source of long-term sustainable energy for their society was lost on arrival.

As the Nome Architect, your job is to lead the construction of the new Nome colony, centred around the World Tree. Build flourishing swathes of terrain, ensuring you gather enough energy to support the World Tree and the community until you can recover the Golden Seed and ensure your Nome colony has the resources it needs to be self-sufficient.

Gameplay

The puzzle gameplay in *Solace* relies primarily on the balancing of competing objectives to maintain player interest. Players engage with multiple mechanics concurrently, attempting to maximise a combination of conditions to find the most elegant solution for each turn.

Mechanics include:

- Connecting a chain of roots of the same colour
- Placing tiles of the same terrain type adjacent to one another
- Fulfilling specific tile goals
- Exploring the game board to enable larger root networks
- Discovering points of interest around the map

By creating a turn-based structure where players can take as long as they like to deliberate, and giving players the tools to rearrange their grid at their leisure during each turn, *Solace* creates an environment where players are rewarded for clever solutions and experience “eureka moments” when they slot in the perfect tile for their new layout.

Unlike other comparable titles in the genre, the game steers away from punishing a player by locking in their previous mistakes, and instead allows the player to rearrange freely allowing players to find the best solution with their available resources every turn and react to any number of strategy altering elements discovered per turn.

Key Game Mechanics

World Tree

The World Tree is the heart of your colony, supporting your root network and enabling life to flourish deep in space. Gameplay wise, the World Tree will power any root that touches one of its sides (adjacent tiles highlighted in yellow on the picture to the right), allowing energy to be carried forward based on the energised roots orientation.

The World Tree also acts as the place where players can:

- Take new tiles
- End their turn
- View their current score

The way that the mechanics above are currently displayed to the player is intentionally very diegetic, purposefully circumventing immersion dampening UI and aiming to keep players grounded in their world. The design for this will be further iterated based on playtesting results throughout the development of the game.

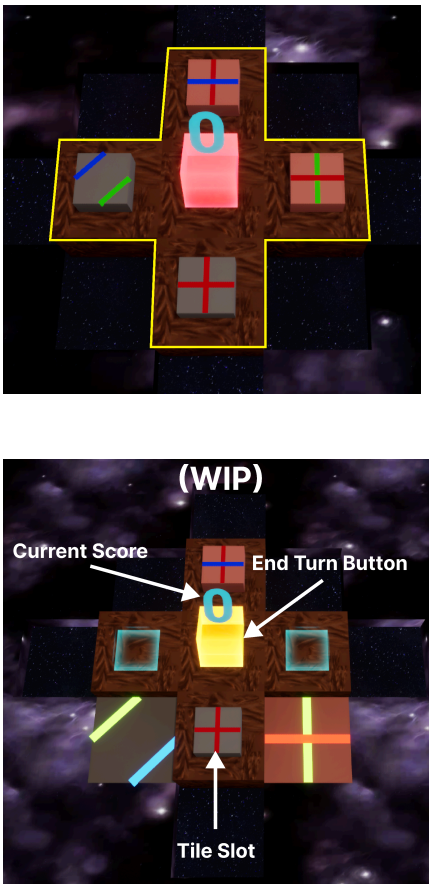

Image 3: Images above demonstrate the core functionality of the World Tree. They are not intended to communicate aesthetic direction

Root Systems

Players channel the life energy provided by their World Tree through coloured roots. This energy serves to support the landscapes the player creates and in turn allows those landscapes to flourish, bringing additional life energy back to the World Tree as they do so.

The root system is the predominant way in which players interact with the game's systems. Players will rotate, place and move tiles, connecting like-coloured roots to create complex and shifting interweaving layouts.

Roots have the following properties

- Roots come in one of four colours
- Roots always enter and exit the tile at the central point of the tile side
- Roots can be diagonal or straight
- Roots glow when connected to World Tree tiles
- Glowing roots cause connected roots of the same colour to also glow, creating an unbroken line
- When the player ends their turn, the glowing roots visibly transport energy towards the World Tree

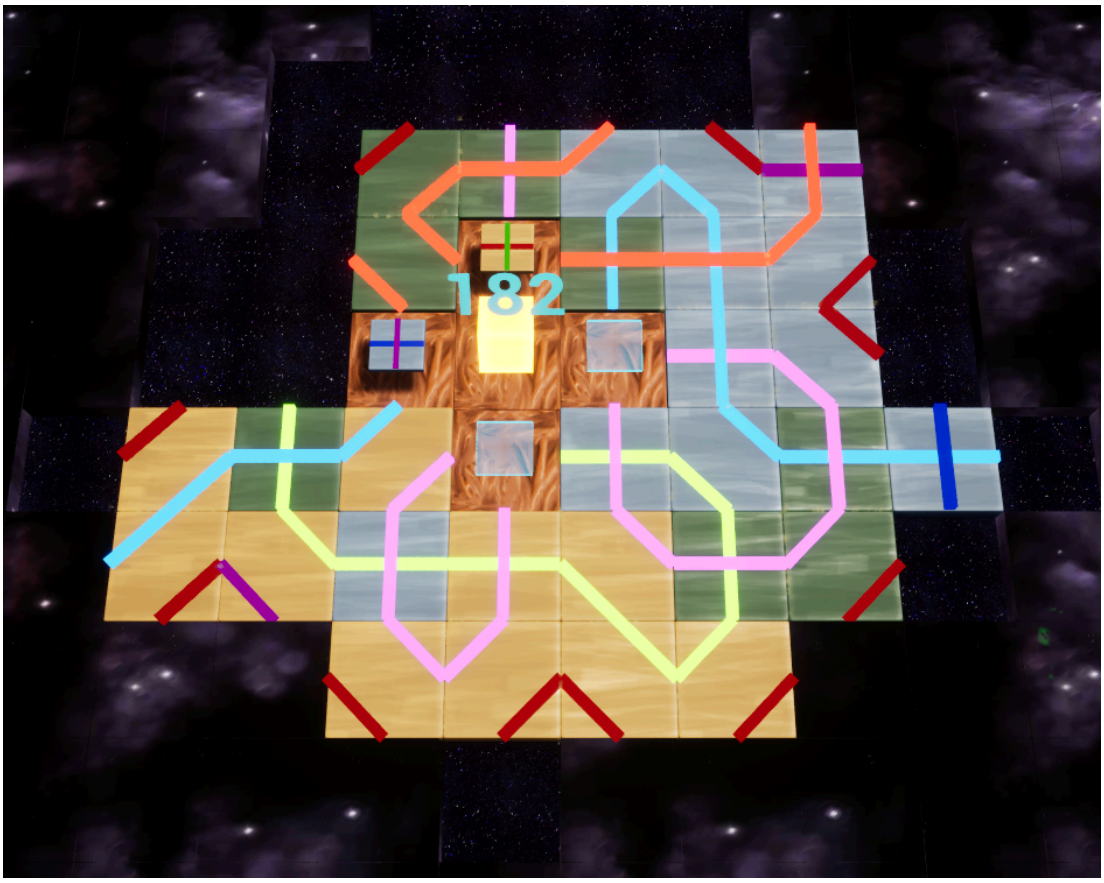

Image 4: The basic functionality of the game board, not intended to communicate aesthetic direction

Tile Biomes & Flourishing

Tiles come in one of 3 biomes:

- Taiga
- Grasslands
- Jungle

As tiles of the same biome group together, they become stronger and generate additional life energy through flourishing.

Tiles flourish at the end of the turn when they are energised and have an adjacent energised tile of the same type (indicated by sparkling particles). Each time a tile flourishes, it earns the player one energy.

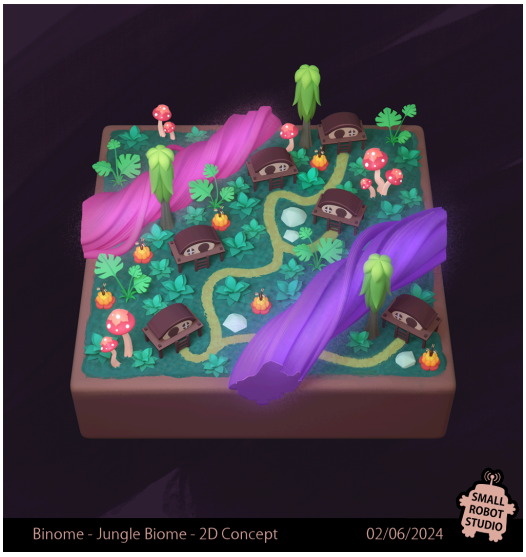

Image 5: Concept for the jungle biome

If a tile has more than one adjacent energised tile, it will flourish multiple times in the turn. For example, an energised tile with three adjacent tiles of the same biome will flourish three times. This rule results in clustered biomes earning more energy so that players are rewarded for constructing tightly packed, efficient root networks.

Tile Upgrades

When a tile has flourished four times during a single turn (matching biomes on all adjacent tiles), it will permanently upgrade, resulting in an additional energy whenever it flourishes from that point on. Each tile can upgrade a maximum of three times in the course of a game.

Nebula Fog

The space outside of that inhabited by the Nomes is covered in a thick nebula, obscuring anything that doesn't emit the life energy provided by the World Tree. As players grow their colony and generate more life energy, they'll begin to clear away this obscuring cosmic dust.

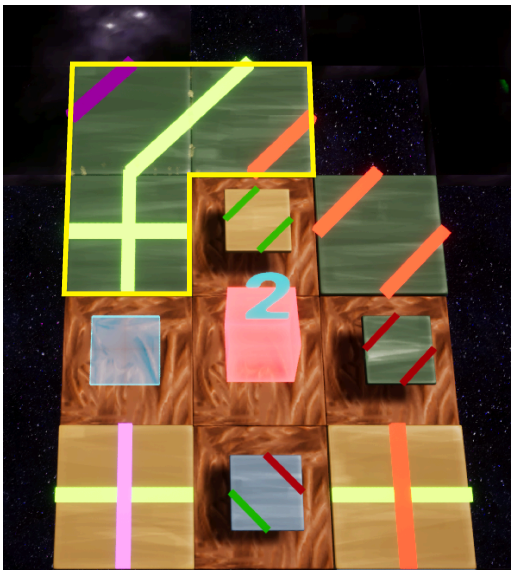

Image 6: Demonstrating the functionality of the 'flourishing' mechanic. This player would gain an additional four energy units when these tiles flourished during their turn.

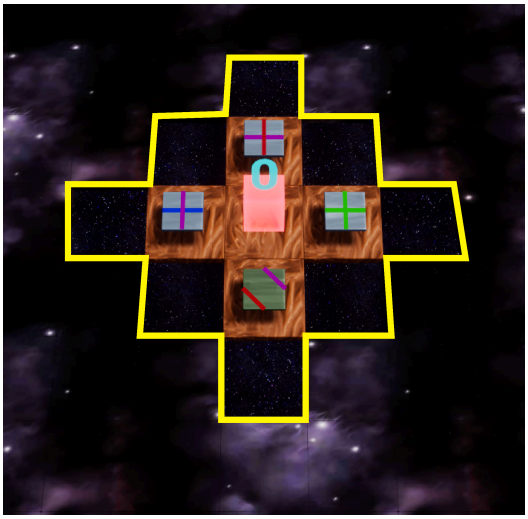

Image 7: Demonstrates the location of the nebula tiles on the starting board.

Image 8: Demonstrates the location of the nebula tiles during a typical game progression.

The starting game board is covered in a fog of nebula with the exception of the tiles adjacent to the World Tree. Players may not place terrain tiles in spots occupied by nebula, however an energised tile will clear all adjacent nebula at the end of the turn allowing players to carve out additional play space as they progress. As players clear out the nebula they not only create more play space but also periodically find gameplay elements such as a free tile or a “place of power” hidden under the layering of cosmic dust.

Places Of Power

Nestled within the nebula fog are forgotten places of power special to the Nomes and their culture. Long neglected, these locations are devoid of energy and life, and it is up to the Nome Architect to reinvigorate them. Players uncover these game-changing locations at random, finding different ones hidden throughout the map each time they play and requiring players to rethink and adjust their strategy in each playthrough.

Unlocking - Tile Requirements

Places of Power are inert when first discovered by Nome exploration and must be unlocked by players before they can be used or moved in any way. Players know what the tile can be used for once activated. Each Place of Power has specific requirements that must be met in order to unlock it. Examples of these requirements include but are not limited to:

- Energised roots totalling at least eight tiles must input to the Place of Power tile
- All inputs on the Place of Power tile must be energised

A rudimentary exploration of the “energised root-length minimum” idea can be seen to the right. In this example, the player has input a length of two energised roots but needs more remaining to fully power the tile. The communication of requirements for the Place of Power tiles will be further iterated based on playtesting results throughout the development of the game.

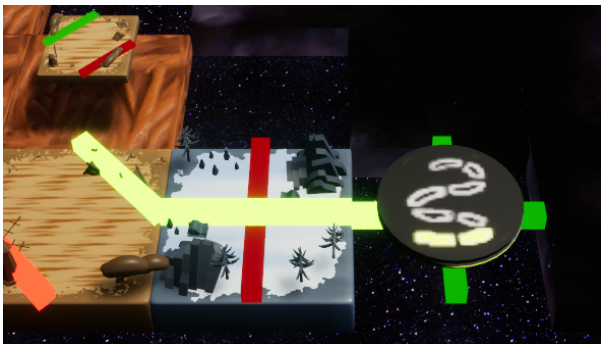

Image 9: Demonstrates a Place of Power tile not yet unlocked for player usage. The image above demonstrates the planned functionality for this mechanic and is not intended to communicate aesthetic direction.

These requirements are incorporated diegetically into the tile itself, allowing players to form an intuitive and immediate link from their actions to the change in tile state.

Once the requirements are fulfilled, the Place of Power is unlocked for the Nome colony to interact with and ready to be activated in a future turn.

Activating - Tile Requirements

Once a Place of Power has been unlocked, it can be moved around the board using the same controls as other tiles. There is a further activation requirement at this stage before

players can reap the rewards of the Place of Power, ensuring that players are required to think strategically and plan ahead over multiple turns to unlock and activate these features.

Examples of requirements to activate the Places of Power include but are not limited to:

- All adjacent biomes match this tile
- All adjacent tiles are upgraded
- Sides must be energised by specific root colours

If these requirements are met when the player ends their turn, the Place of Power effect will activate. Effects of this may include but are not limited to:

- Causes any adjacent Taiga tiles to flourish an additional time
- Produces a free tile
- Clears nebula in a radius
- Upgrades a random tile

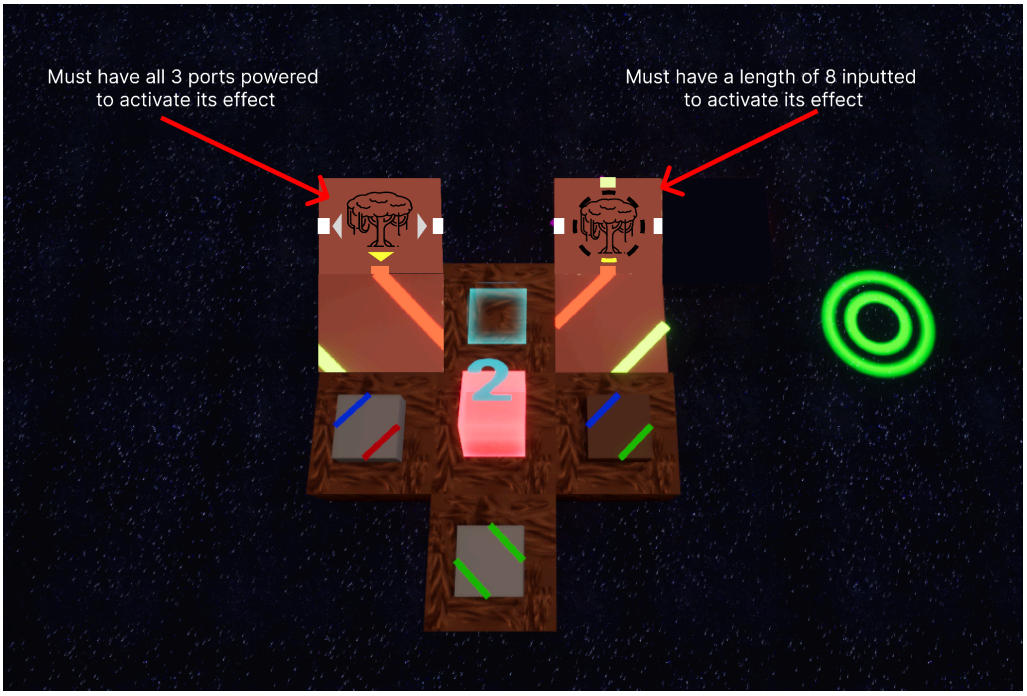

Image 10: Demonstrates two different Places of Power unlocked but not yet activated by the player. The image above demonstrates the planned functionality for this mechanic and is not intended to communicate aesthetic direction.

Game Modes

Golden Seed Mode

This is the standard play mode of *Solace*. Players are tasked with finding the heart of their World Tree before it runs out of energy and becomes inert.

The player's World Tree requires an increasing amount of energy to sustain itself every turn. Players provide this energy through positive gameplay actions such as flourishing and clearing nebula fog. Eventually the energy cost of each turn will exceed what the player can feasibly produce. Before this point, players must uncover the Golden Seed and recover it, providing the World Tree with the energy it needs for the future.

To recover the seed, players must:

- Discover the location of the 3 seed conduits (Special Places Of Power)
- Discover the location of the Golden Seed itself
- Fulfil the requirements of the 3 seed conduits
- Collect the Golden Seed

Once players collect the Golden Seed, the World Tree is able to produce all the energy the Nomes could need, and the player's Nome colony is self-sufficient from then on, ending the player's run.

Endless

This mode features an endless map and is devoid of any direct win state. Players deal with the increasing energy costs of their World Tree, attempting to keep ahead of the curve, growing their colony for as long as they can. This mode is supported by an unobtrusive leaderboard to cater to players looking for a more competitive experience as they are likely to be the ones more interested in this limit-testing game mode.

World Sculpting - Creative Mode

This mode has no gameplay restrictions, simply allowing players to freely place down tiles from a UI element. This mode seeks to enable players looking to landscape without the need for gameplay pressures.

Meta Progression

Achievements

Solace includes a number of in-game Achievements for players to complete. Achievements reward player's progress throughout their journey with *Solace*, acknowledging and encouraging player milestones with gameplay rewards.

Gameplay achievements include but are not limited to:

- Form a jungle biome of at least 20 tiles
- Collect 6000 energy in total
- Finish an endless run with at least 3000 energy collected
- Finish a golden seed run in 15 turns or less

Each gameplay challenge has an associated reward such as:

- Unlockable colour palettes
    - Selectable colour palettes that alter the player's biome colours, allowing for greater customization of their colony
- New Places of Power
    - Unlock more Place of Power types that can be discovered during a run

Ascendancy

Every time a player completes a Golden Seed run they unlock some additional options related to this mode. The first options unlocked allow players to increase the map size so that they can increase their run length to medium or large, increasing play time per run. Subsequent Golden Seed completions allow players to level up or Ascend. Ascension options allow players to tune the difficulty to their liking, increasing the challenge of the Golden Seed mode. Each time a player completes a specific Ascension level they unlock the next one which proves more challenging than the last.

Ascension modifiers may include but are not limited to:

- +1 extra root colour
- +1 extra biome
- Junk tiles added to the board
- Higher energy cost requirements each turn
- Tiles lock in position after 3 turns

Accessibility

Solace has been carefully designed to create a relaxing, engaging and immersive environment that is accommodating and comfortable. for a wide range of players. The team dislikes the idea of excluding anyone from being able to enjoy *Solace* simply due to lacking accessibility options. In order to achieve the most impact, accessibility will be targeted in the following areas for release.

Colour Blind Modes

As the core mechanics of *Solace* rely heavily on colour and shape, it's important to adequately account for colour blindness in development. The game comes with a suite of colour blind modes for players to choose from inside the options menu.

The root system used in *Solace* has some key challenges when considering colour blindness as it is based primarily around colour. To circumvent this issue, each coloured root has a distinct shape identity, allowing them to be differentiated even in greyscale. A similar method can be found in the board game *Isle Of Cats* (The City of Games, March 2020)

Image 11: An image from the board game* The Isle of Cats*, credit [The City of Games](#).

Controller Support

The UI in Solace is deliberately unobtrusive in order to increase player world immersion, and that most gameplay communication is diegetic. The limited number of onscreen buttons, menus, and HUDs ensures that controller support can be added with minimal risk of costly UI rework.

Other Accessibility Options

Control Rebinding

Players are given the ability to rebind any and all controls within the game to suit their specific needs

UI Scaling & Font Choice

All UI present within the game is scalable so that it remains suitable for a range of screen sizes and vision levels. Along with this, fonts used in the game are specifically picked to be thick and easily readable at a wide range of resolutions

Dead Zone Configurability

This option is specifically important for players using a controller, and allows users to specify how large the “dead zone” is on their controller. This option is especially useful for players who struggle with fine motor control but is also applicable to those who experience “controller drift”.

Movement Sensitivity

Solace requires players to move a cursor around their screen, clicking and dragging tiles. This requires some accuracy on the players’ part and as such we allow them to tailor their cursor's movement speed to accommodate their level of motor control.

Art & Animation

Art style

The art style in *Solace* creates a beautiful, peaceful and cosy atmosphere for the player in which they feel comfortable and empowered taking time considering how best to grow their Nome colony.

As the primary focus of *Solace*, the eponymous Nomes act as a unifying visual theme in every aspect of the game aesthetic. An intriguing blend of space-faring cosmic explorers, woodland creatures, and celestial folkloric tradition, the Nomes are uniquely designed for this game.

Image 12: Initial design for one of the Nome characters

Tiles

Solace encourages the player to build a thriving Nome colony through interacting with the terrain tiles. These tiles are the predominant way that the player interacts with *Solace's* gameplay systems, because of this it's extremely important that these tiles are visually striking, immersive and just pleasant to look at in general.

Tile Concepts

Using the initial nome concepts as a starting point, we have created concepts for the three primary biomes. These concepts serve to ground the game's visual style and provide the team with a shared understanding of the end product when considering 3D implementation of in-game tile assets, especially with regard to the core gameplay loop and atmosphere.

Image 13: Concepts for the tiles. From left to right: jungle, grassland, taiga

Tile Procedural Generation

A cornerstone of the project is the feeling of building **your own unique** Nome colony, to this end the team has opted to leverage Unreal Engine's PCG (Procedural Content Generation) system in construction of our tiles. Each tile the player obtains will be completely procedurally generated giving the feeling that each terrain piece is truly being crafted for the first time and giving the player a greater level of investment in the little world they are creating for their Nomes.

Image 14: Concept for the grassland biome

UI

The UI of *Solace* is minimalistic and understated to ensure that the player's focus remains on the tiles and the world that they are building.

Player interaction is intuitive, utilising click-and-drag functionality for almost all operations. This is a key aspect of the design for *Solace* as the target player demographic are familiar with technology but have varying levels of familiarity with traditional game interfaces.

The use of diegetic elements and intuitive input methods in tile interactions limits the need for overt explanatory text or tutorialisation.

Art Inspiration

The visual style and art direction of *Solace* is influenced by other isometric tile-placing games which have found global success. One main influence is *Dorfromantik*, which focuses on environment and miniaturisation without the loss of individuality or charm. One notable point of difference between the two games is that *Solace* leans less into "board game aesthetic" theming.

Image 15:* Dorfromantik*, Toukana Interactive, 28 Apr, 2022

Other inspirations for art direction include:

Image 16: **Landnama,** ***Sonderland, 31 Jul, 2023***

Image 17: **Terra Nil,** ***Free Lives, Clockwork Acorn, 28 March, 2023***

Image 18: **For The King,** ***IronOak Games, 20 Apr, 2018***

Animation

Tile Animation

The need for animation in *Solace* is limited due to the genre and gameplay, however in some specific cases we use it to emphasise certain actions, adding to the organic atmosphere of the game and giving feedback to player actions. Such cases may include and are not limited to:

- Energy generation
- Picking up, rotating, or placing a tile
- Upgrading a tile
- Unlocking or activating a Place of Power

Many of these animations will focus on maximum impact with minimal complexity, using techniques such as squash and stretch to bounce tiles. Similar examples can be found in

Terra Nil where tiles fluidly bounce as they convert from wasteland to greenery. We look to implement similar behaviour as energy travels down the players root systems, bulging the mesh as it travels back towards the World Tree

Nomes

2D sprites of the Nomes are also included where relevant. These Nomes wander across the tops of your tiles, making your colony feel that much more alive. *The Wandering Village* (Stray Fawn Studio, 15 Sep, 2022) demonstrates how strategic use of sprites can replace resource-intensive 3D animation without compromising on gameplay or visual theming such as in this case..

Image 19: Example of art from* The Wandering Village *(Stray Fawn, 2022)

Sound Design

The Nomes

Sound design in *Solace* is heavily influenced by the art style and theming
of the Nomes. The sound in-game works subtly with the visual aesthetic to create a soundscape which grounds the player in the Nome community. This ensures that they feel invested in the space they're helping to build as well as creating a unique auditory identity for the game. Themes for *Solace* sound direction include:

- Woodland
- Celestial
- Curious
- Jovial
- Enigmatic

Auditory Feedback

Sound design for *Solace* prioritises an immersive player experience. Each action is matched by a satisfying, grounded sound such as shuffling dirt when manipulating tiles, shifting bark when a root is extended, or positive chimes when the player scores points or achieves a Nome Council objective. These sounds aid in building the player's satisfaction when interacting with the game.

Ambient Sounds

Ambient sound is crucial to creating the peaceful, engaging atmosphere which is central to *Solace* gameplay. As the Nomes go about their day-to-day lives throughout the game, the player hears sounds such as:

- Birdsong
- Light construction
- Chimes
- Bells
- Nome Chatter

Image 20: The above images are early 2D concepts for the Nome characters

Soundtrack

The *Solace* soundtrack immerses the player in the terrain they are shaping and gives them a greater emotional connection to the Nomes and the world they inhabit.

Gameplay in *Solace* is accompanied by peaceful acoustic music which fits the player experience. The soundtrack is designed to provide a relaxing background atmosphere rather than being centred in the foreground of the player's aural environment.

Inspiration for the soundtrack direction includes:

- *Dorfromantik*
    - Mysterious, calming
    - Futuristic, cosmic
- Ambient forest birdsong and nature sounds
- Pagan-style instruments
- Woodland tones

As the game is leaning quite heavily into using minimalistic UI, audio communication is key in making sure the player has substantial feedback accompanying their actions. *Solace* will use distinct audio cues to tell players when a positive or negative action occurs in combination with the usual visual cues.

Playtesting

Jellyfish & Giants heavily incorporates playtesting throughout our projects, in line with our "Test the fun" business strategy. *Solace* has been no different, rigorously playtested regularly throughout the design and prototyping phases. *Solace* was thoroughly paper prototyped for the first six months of the project and tested on a number of players. This process helped finetune the game's core mechanics and confirm that this project would meet the requirements of the target player base in order to ensure that it was worth pursuing..

More recently, we held a base mechanics playtest for the digital version of the game in an effort to validate that the core loop remained strong and additionally to verify that the core demographic were interested in the product we were making for them.

Core Mechanics Prototype Testing (Full Response List Here)

For this test we had a total of 8 players at an average of 1.5 hours per playtesting session, These players were specifically chosen to reflect our core demographic.

Root System

Even with the purely mechanical implementation of this feature, players resonated with it and found the process of creating their root system satisfying. This is one of the core

mechanics of *Solace* so the positive response is encouraging. We are confident that with polish and further development the reception to this mechanic will be even stronger.

Comparator Games

Our players were very familiar with the games we are using as direct reference for competitor analysis, especially *Mini Motorways* (*Dinosaur Polo Club*, 2019) however all of our testers are from New Zealand and work in or around the games industry so that likely skews that fact.

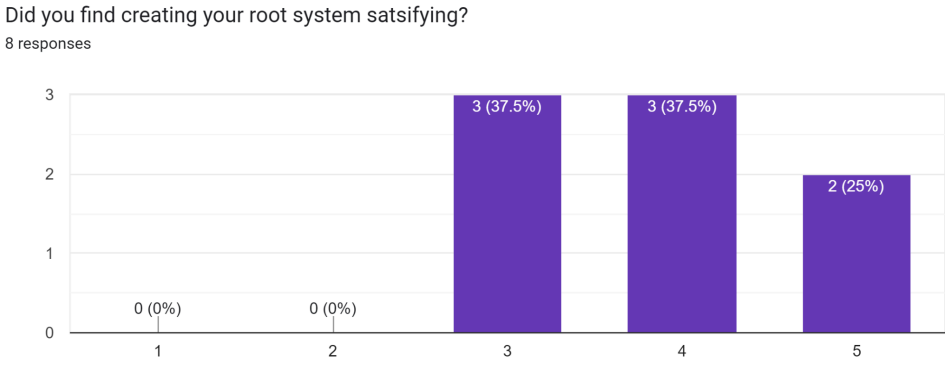

Figure 21: **Playtesting root feedback**

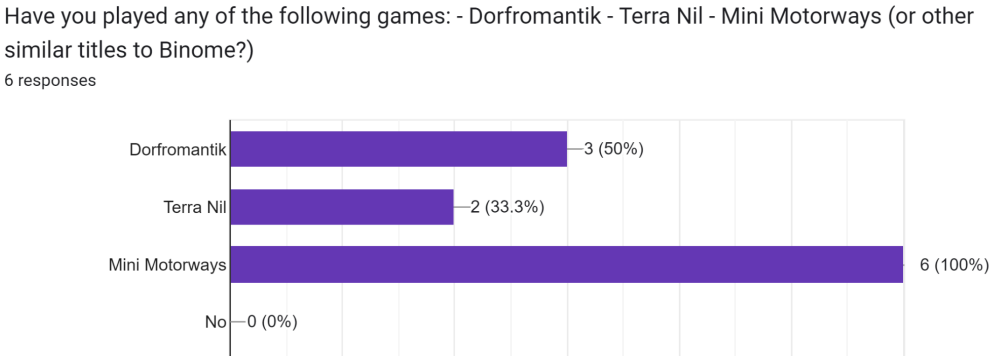

Figure 22: **Playtesting comparators responses**

Conclusions (Full List Here)

This testing made clear to us that the core mechanics were very compelling for players, and also helped to clarify which features our target demographic are interested in. This will help to drive prioritisation for feature implementations and design, and also for future playtesting. Features to further explore and test include:

- Greater quality of life options surrounding tile manipulation
    - Tile group select
    - Swap tile positions through click and drag
    - Per round tile layout save and load
- Deeper tile complexity
    - Tiles that split roots into two or “splitters”

    - More meaningful upgraded tiles
- Less obtrusive blocker tiles
- Stronger long term objectives (Meta game loop)
    - Endless Modes
    - Gameplay “Builds”

Post Playtest

After the playtest we reevaluated our roadmap to include some new features aimed at directly addressing the feedback we received.

Feedback: Less obtrusive blocker tiles
Change: Nebula clouds
The nebula clouds were designed after this playtest in response to players' negative response to a more aggressive feature that forced players to rearrange their grid every turn. The nebula acts as positive reinforcement of the same behaviour instead

Feedback: Deeper tile complexity
Change: Places of Power
Places of Power are a response to players wanting more ramping complexity and concretely strong gameplay moves that reward skillful play.

Feedback: Stronger long-term objectives
Change: Endless game mode
The endless game mode will satisfy those players who wanted for a more sprawling root network.

Change: Golden Seed Retrieval Game Mode
The Golden Seed retrieval game mode will satisfy those players who told us they wanted more concrete long term goals.

Unique Selling Point (USP)

Solace has what it takes to stand out in today's market and exhibits many unique strengths not seen before in our target market such as:

- A refreshing aesthetic blending spacefaring and woodland themes
- Strong use of diegetic gameplay communication creates a uniquely lightweight player experience
- A new take on the relaxing tile placement puzzle that utilises an intuitive interlocking root mechanic
- Art that diverts from the established low poly/board game aesthetic and instead creates a vibrant densely populated world
- A dynamic playspace that is organically widened by the player

- Randomly generated game tiles ensuring that each player's world is truly unique to them

Project Goals

Successful paper and digital prototype testing of the core mechanical loop in *Solace* confirmed the potential for success in the target market. The CODE grant would enable the next phase of development.

With the funding, the *Solace* team will deliver the following within the 40-week deliverable timeline:

- A highly polished playable publisher demo
- A comprehensive pitch deck for publishing partners
- An established online community and Steam page

These deliverables will work to demonstrate the unique selling points of *Solace* and serve as a key tool in attracting further funding to fully develop and launch the game.

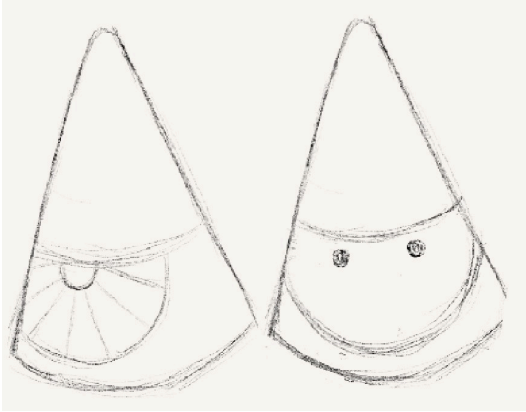

Image 23: Early Nome shape exploration

In preparation for this, a list of potential publisher partners have been assessed on a preliminary basis for suitability. Additional publishers will be assessed closer to the time of outreach

Current Top Three Publisher Picks

Whitethorn Games

- **This studio is currently the preferred option for a *Solace* publisher.**
- The Whitethorn mission statement aligns closely with the *Solace* vision, focused on supporting games that are "pleasant and easy-going".
- An additional priority is "accessibility, inclusion, and widening the audience that gets to play", which also matches the *Solace* goals of attracting a player base who may not play more traditional games.
- Preliminary research showed that Whitethorn Games appear to fund a lot of games with more upbeat art styles, similar to art direction for *Solace*.
- Whitethorn Games have a proven record as a publisher, with some very successful titles.

Brace Yourself Games

- Brace Yourself Games has a catalogue of successful and recognisable titles

- The studio has published many base-building/management games, some of which used tile-based grids. This suggests that *Solace* could capitalise on existing marketing strategies, communities, channels, and specific experience within the studio.
- Developers had ongoing relationships with this publisher for multiple game releases. This suggests that they had positive and mutually beneficial partnerships.
- Publishing Slate currently full as of writing this

Goblinz Studio

- Goblinz Studio has a high density of simulation/management games in their catalogue. This suggests that *Solace* could capitalise on existing marketing strategies, communities, channels, and specific experience within the studio.
- The studio has a high quality bar and multiple titles with good public recognition.
- Preliminary research appears to show that Goblinz Studio has a high success rate on released titles.
- Possible *Solace*'s genre is slightly out of their usual specialisation of "Simulation and strategy games"

Our Team

The Jellyfish & Giants team has comprehensive game development experience. This experience ensures that the team has the technical skill needed to execute on the design vision and deliver a high-quality game.

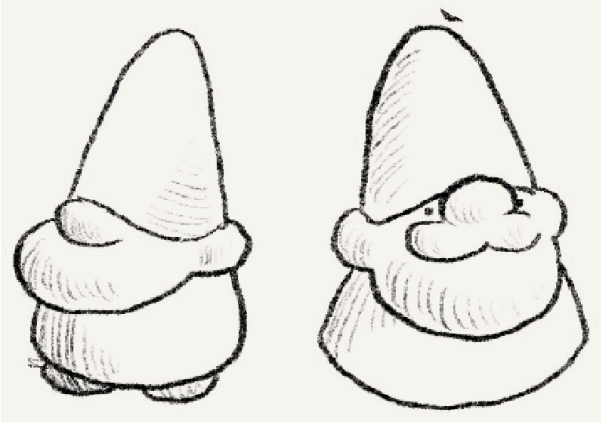

Image 24: Early Nome character development sketch

Jonty Hoekstra (He/Him) - *Programmer, Designer, VFX*

Jonty is a professional game designer with a Bachelors of Software Engineering and has over four years experience in a variety of game development environments. Currently based in Ōtautahi, Jonty has been working as a game designer at CerebralFix for the past three years. Previously, Jonty worked on an indie title called *Mythos* Party. Over the past year, Jonty has been working independently with colleagues from CerebralFix creating game prototypes

Taylor Mudgway (He/Him) - *3D Artist, VFX*

Taylor possesses a broad skill set spanning 3D animation, rigging, modelling, and VFX, cultivated over four years of game development education. With two years' experience as a

3D artist and a seamless transition into VFX since January 2023, Taylor has demonstrated versatility and proficiency in enhancing gaming experiences through captivating visuals.

Keegan Gibson (He/Him) - *Programmer*

Keegan has been in game development for nearly 15 years, specialising in Unreal Engine, networking, performance, and AI. Throughout his career, he has worked on a diverse range of projects, including mobile, console, PC, indie, and AAA titles, as well as making some short contributions to film.

Jasper Lyons (He/Him) - *Sound Engineer, Programmer*

Jasper is an experienced sound engineer and game developer who is currently working as a full-time intermediate web developer. Since graduating from Media Design School with a Bachelor of Software Engineering, Jasper has worked as a full stack web developer, game programmer, animation tools engineer, sound engineer, composer, producer, and 3D artist. Jasper has a passion for everything sound and music, and enjoys spending his personal time composing music, and developing his abilities as an audio engineer for games.

Sabrina Cooke (She/They) - *Programmer*

Sabrina is a professional game programmer with a Bachelors of Product Design from the University of Canterbury and 1-2 years of industry experience. Sabrina currently works as a programmer at CerebralFix, a game studio based in Otautahi, New Zealand. She has created experiences in Unity and Unreal for PC, XR, web, and mobile, while also fostering diversity, equity, and inclusion among her teams.

The Studio - Jellyfish & Giants

Founded by Jonty Hoekstra, Jellyfish & Giants is a small studio focused on developing games with punchy premises, focused small-scale design, and inclusive themes.

Jellyfish & Giants believes games are too often created in a way that excludes large portions of the possible audience. Their aim is to bring more titles into the world that are fun, engaging, and inclusive!

Studio Goals

Jellyfish & Giants operates with the following goals in mind:

- Provide meaningful gameplay experiences for as many people as possible
- Provide a sustainable outlet for artistic expression within the studio
- Uplift and empower the local game development industry

Business Strategy

To achieve the studio goals, Jellyfish & Giants employs the following strategies in order to cultivate a low-risk, focused development method.

Keep Games Focused: Jellyfish & Giants believes in creating punchy experiences that don't require a huge budget to bring to life. This means designing focused experiences that perform to a high standard while staying within a reasonable scope.

Market Led Design: Design does not exist in a vacuum; products are created for an audience. When creating games, Jellyfish & Giants make sure to understand the market landscape. Competitors, audiences, genres, and existing market analysis are thoroughly researched and this informs the games during development. This research does not dominate creative decision-making. Instead it is used to keep the team informed and, in tandem with the creative vision, helps guide the development process.

Image 25: Paper prototyping

Diversity Is Strength: Diversity within the team strengthens their ability to consider every aspect of a problem. It aids in out-of-the-box design and problem-solving and reduces the chance of unmitigated risks. This strategy plays a very important part in team composition and structure.

Currently the team is less diverse than we'd like and it's something we'll be keenly focusing on whenever we look to bring new members into the team. For example, when contracting our 2D concepts we've kept this in mind and have benefited greatly from our key 2D concept artist being a woman of colour, adding a different perspective (along with her extreme talent and concepting skill).

Test The Fun: Game development is an unpredictable and evolving environment and as such, Jellyfish & Giants believe in keeping risk as low as possible when planning projects. To this end playtesting is prioritised with a diverse range of people, using paper prototypes and vertical slices to great effect throughout development.

All of these strategies have been incorporated through the early stages of developing *Solace* and will continue to be incorporated going forward.

Studio Growth Strategy

Jellyfish & Giants is committed to remaining a small sustainable studio. This means that the long-term team is limited to a small number of talented individuals working closely together to create stunning, cohesive projects. Any growth in team size will involve deep

consideration of necessary roles needed within the studio and the inclusion of voices and perspectives missing from the current team.

Jellyfish & Giants prioritises creating a safe and sustainable environment in which game developers can find fair working conditions. Success means reinvesting in people and the game development industry within Aotearoa.

Production

Overview

The following image is a high-level breakdown of the planned development milestones for *Solace*. It covers the publisher demo development funded by this grant as well as the time and additional funding needed to finish the game to completion. The detailed publisher demo roadmap can be found **here**. Please note that projected start dates are an estimate and likely to be adjusted based on funding logistics

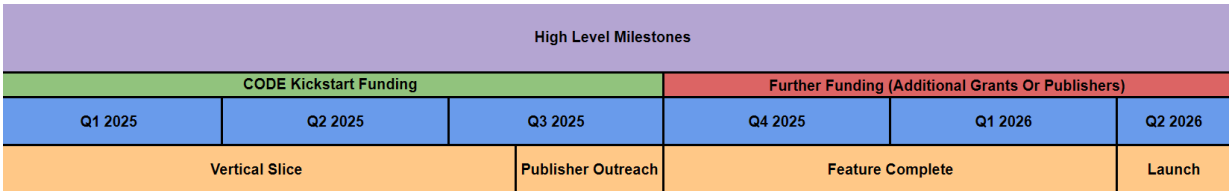

Figure 26: **High Level Milestones**

Milestones

The major milestones for the *Solace* publisher demo will occur as detailed in the roadmap. The first three publisher demo milestones mark points where the game will have a stable build to be tested, and where feedback can be gathered in order to inform upcoming development. The fourth and final milestone marks the point where publisher outreach can begin.

There are three major development milestones detailed on the roadmap:

Milestone One: Game Mode Testing

At this stage of development the player will have clear objectives and be able to interact in a meaningful way with the golden seed game mode. This milestone build will focus on testing and feedback for the pacing of the game.

Milestone Two: Pre-polish testing

At this milestone the game is ready for stress-testing. This will inform polish tasks, bug fixing and any final development as well as serving to help ensure that the game is ready for any

upcoming events that might allow the team to accumulate buzz surrounding the game and acquire wishlists.

Such events may include:

- Yogscast Tiny Teams
- Steam Strategy Fest
- Steam Next Fest (This will be saved for closer to release once *Solace* has acquired at least 7.5k wishlists and/or has acquired a publishing partner)
- The Mix Next
- TurnBasedFest

The team will be monitoring for events as they appear using resources such as **this** list

It should be noted that any major Steam events that involve games in the identified market niche for *Solace* will shift priorities and potentially timelines as these are invaluable opportunities to gain traction before launch.

Other notable production markers during this phase include the creation of a Steam page. This event is important as it can generate an influx of wishlists if done effectively. It is strategically positioned on the timeline to allow sufficient time for a 2D artist to create compelling concepts, mockups, capsule art and UI assets for the game to attract the target audience. By this stage there will also be in-game screenshots and videos which will give a clear picture of the gameplay in order to convert casual views to wishlists.

Milestone Three: Publisher Outreach

At this stage the team will have an impressive polished publisher demo for *Solace*. This can be leveraged alongside the community metrics accumulated to reach out to each of the preferred publishers with a prepared pitch document and publisher demo. This time can also be used for additional polish and marketing/player outreach.

At this point the team will be proactively looking for opportunities and events to get *Solace* in front of a publisher, looking to draw attention both in person and online. CODE travel grants will likely be an option the team pursues towards that end. Events may include:

- PAX AUS
- Gamescom
- GDC
- etc.

Next Steps (Post Publisher Demo)

Feature Complete

At the point where funding is assured for the remainder of development, the team will begin full production of the feature-complete game.

As the game loop in *Solace* is systemic rather than content-driven, the primary goals for this next phase are to build out the game's auxiliary systems. These include and are not limited to:

- Colour blind support
- Zen Mode
- Unlockable colour palettes
- Rebindable controls
- Saving/loading
- Challenge modes
- Game modifiers

As the game's loop and art will be in a polished, complete state, the team will escalate the *Solace* marketing campaign in this phase. Depending on funding circumstances, this marketing may be handled by a publisher alongside the team as work continues on the remaining features.

Following this, the team would look to launch *Solace*, releasing it onto Steam.

Finances

The full financial plan can be found here. The team will be asking for a total of $39,796.00

In accordance with our studio values, the financial plan is designed to allow for team members to be paid at a fair market rate. These wages have been calculated based on market rates at the level of experience that the team members possess.

Scope

As the scope of *Solace* is deliberately small and achievable, a team of four multi-disciplinary professionals working over nine months can meet the project goal of creating a polished publisher demo for use in acquiring a publishing partner. Not all members will be needed full-time during this period; 2D art and audio will have specific times during the project with a higher workload, and other times where requirements are lower or more flexible.

Additional 2D art will be contracted soon after funding, initially prioritising concepts to further shape art development going forward. Subsequently, their main tasks will involve

producing marketing collateral, including promotional images for the *Solace* Steam page, such as:

- Header capsule art
- Main capsule art
- Vertical capsule
- Page background
- Thumbnails

These resources will also be utilised for the publisher pitch deck and social media posts.

The team will be seeking to again contract *Small Robot Studio* for these 2D tasks. *Small Robot Studio* have already been contracted to create tile concepts for *Solace* before and are known by the team personally and professionally.

Marketing And Outreach Costs

Marketing time has been allowed for in the budget provided. This time is allotted to organically build a community around the game through social media and Discord as well as reaching out to potential publishing partners later in the process.

Further Funding

If the need for additional funding is identified to complete the publisher demo or to develop the game further while continuing the search for an appropriate publisher, the following options can be further explored:

Image 27: Concept for the taiga biome

CODE Startup Funding

Additional CODE funding could be used to complete the second stage of the project. At this point the team will have some potential publisher contacts and a polished publisher demo ready to be taken into full production and subsequent storefront release.

CODE Travel Grants

The team is eager to get out to events, network with potential publishers and also get the game into players hands as soon as possible. CODE travel grants are designed for this purpose. Jellyfish & Giants have lodged an EOI already and look forward to the possibilities it could bring.

Mega Grants

As *Solace* is being developed in Unreal Engine, the game is eligible for an unreal Mega Grant. These grants are a positive opportunity for teams working within Unreal Engine and can lead to many further opportunities.

Market Analysis

The market for "peaceful, minimalist, city-building puzzle" games is booming. This is demonstrated by and partially attributable to the popularity of Dorfromantik which has sold an estimated 1.2 million copies (based on review count). Success is not limited to high-profile games such as Dorfromantik; there are plenty of lower-profile titles being released which are also popular with players. Examples include:

Figure 28: Steam Genre Trends

- Terrascape (Bitfall, 6 Apr, 2023)
    - 527 reviews (very positive)
- Landnama (Sonderland, 31 Jul, 2023)
    - 364 reviews (Mostly Positive)
- Can't Live Without Electricity (MELOVITY, 14 Apr, 2023)
    - 191 reviews (very positive)
- Pan'orma (Chicken Launcher, 10 May, 2023)
    - 810 reviews (very positive)
- Land Above Sea Below (Glasscannon Studio, 14 Sep, 2023)
    - 83 reviews (very positive)

To further support the given market analysis, this chart shows the follower count trend and review trends across Steam for games with tags "city builder", "relaxing", and "turn-based strategy"

Breakeven					
Target Price	**$**	**15.00**	**Breakeven @**	3650	**units**
Comparison					
Target Reviews		*< 64*	*± 114*	*> 274*	
Game Title	**Reefland**		**Land Above Sea Below**	**Pan'orama**	
Actual Reviews		74	83	810	
Unit Price	$	7.39	$ 11.79	$ 20.49	
Target Units		2555	4563	10950	
Actual Units		2960	3320	32400	
Sales	$	21,874.40	$ 39,142.80	$663,876.00	

Figure 29: Competitor Boxleiter analysis

Based on this market research and the outcomes from paper and digital prototyping, we are confident *Solace* can reach success levels which match or exceed the higher end of the lower-profile titles mentioned above and will resonate with the same core demographics.

Image 30:* Reefland, *UnSweet, 18 Oct, 2022

Competitor Analysis

Below is a snapshot of three games in similar genres to *Solace* using the process described by Rami Ismail (using a Boxleiter number of 40.) These games show the range of market competitors at each level of success in this genre and act as a comparative measure to predict market performance and return on investment. It should be noted that these values are only accounting for cost related to the publisher demo with the current proposed budget of $39,796.00, relevant competitors include

Competitor with poor performance

Reefland (UnSweet, 18 Oct, 2022) Pros (as reported by Steam reviews)

- Unique hook of painting islands
- Beautiful
- Low price
- “Great to play while listening to podcasts”

- Relaxing to play in short 5-10 minute periods

Cons (as reported by Steam reviews)

- Lack of real challenge - strategy not required
- Overly referential of other game “Islanders”
- No real scoring mechanic to go up against
    - No escalation in gameplay

Image 31:* Land Above Sea Below, *Glasscannon Studio, 14 Sep, 2023

***Solace* Comparison**

The key difference between *Solace* and Reefland is the strength of their core loop and meta progression. *Solace’s* core loop better challenges players looking to go deeper with the game, increasing difficulty of play and strategy requirements through unlocks or harder “ascension” modes along with unique modifiers that keep players interested in the core mechanics for longer. Additionally, things like unlockable colour pallets, leaderboards and multiple game modes that cater to a wider range of players put *Solace* ahead of Reefland in these cases. Competitor with reasonable performance *Land Above Sea Below (Glasscannon Studio, 14 Sep, 2023)*

Pros (as reported by Steam reviews)

- Unique hook of rising sea level
- Beautiful
- Low price
- Stronger puzzle element when compared to Dorfromantik

Cons (as reported by Steam reviews)

- Serious design issues
    - Unclear ruleset and unintuitive gameplay
    - Lack of agency/strategy options - low ability to plan for upcoming challenges
    - Lack of control - feeling of RNG being the sole driver of gameplay
    - Poor tutorialisation
    - Steep difficulty
- Performance Issues at larger scale maps

Solace Comparison

Jellyfish & Giants would take care to avoid similar balancing pitfalls as seen in *Land Above Sea Below* through frequent playtesting and time during development dedicated to polishing in accordance with our "Test The Fun" studio pillar. Players will find *Solace* a much more intuitive experience, more of what they'd expect from a title following in the footsteps of other cosy strategy games and as a result will be much more positively received by the target demographic

Competitor with excellent performance

[Pan'orma (Chicken Launcher, 10 May, 2023)]

Pros (as reported by Steam reviews)

- "Same kind of fun as Dorfromantik but with enough differences to give it its own unique charm"
- Very relaxing
- Has that "one more" feeling
- Does a great job of keeping the player engaged over longer play sessions
- Fulfils the fantasy of creating beautiful landscape very effectively
- Is simple enough on the surface to bring players in but has some strategic depth under the hood to keep them there

Cons (as reported by Steam reviews)

- "Too derivative of Dorfromantik"
- Tutorial doesn't cover the games long term objectives effectively
- "Winning" a run requires a very long time commitment and is extremely RNG dependent
- Game breaking bugs
- Long term objectives clash with relaxing atmosphere

***Solace* Comparison**

Pan'orama does a lot of things right, it manages to scratch the itch for a lot of players who have enjoyed what Dorfromantik could offer them while adding some new mechanics to differentiate itself. However from our research it seems there are many people who believe the game hasn't done enough to differentiate itself. *Solace* demonstrates a stronger identity and can differentiate itself from *Pan'orama* in areas, such as:

Image 32:* Pan'orma *Chicken Launcher, 10 May, 2023

- Strength of visual identity - *Solace* moves away from the "board game" aesthetic first captured in Dorfromantik and now here and instead carves out its own visual nice with its meshed woodland and spacefaring themes.
- Strength of mechanical identity - *Solace* diverts more strongly from comparator games than *Pan'orama*. Such diversions include *Solace's* square tiles, unique coloured root system and biome energy generation.
- Randomly generated tile dressing to keep world construction from getting stale visually
- Post release support/Community Outreach - Pan'orama was left with game breaking bugs for months after release with no response from the development team, one such case prevented players from being able to complete a run at all. We would endeavour to have a much swifter response given any of the same issues.

Target Audience

Understanding our target audience is key if we're going to attempt to create a game that will meaningfully resonate with a large number of players, additionally we need to know where to focus our marketing if it's to be successful. In the following sections we'll begin to hone down on what our target audience might look like and use that information to inform both design and marketing approaches for Solace

Player Segments

The first way we can analyse our target audience is through creating some theoretical player profiles utilising Quantic Foundy's Player Segments.

PLAYER SEGMENTS SUMMARY QUANTIC FOUNDRY

	Acrobat	Gardener	Slayer	Skirmisher	Gladiator
Motto	*"Flexing My Reflexes."*	*"Quiet, Relaxing Task Completion."*	*"Cinematic Mayhem With a Purpose."*	*"Jumping Into The Fray of Battle."*	*"Dedicated, hardcore gaming."*
Top Mot.	Challenge + Discovery	Completion	Fantasy + Story + Destruction	Destruction + Competition	Challenge + Completion + Comm,
Pop Games	Spelunky, Celeste, Super Metroid, Tetris	Candy Crush, Solitaire, Animal Crossing	Firewatch, Uncharted, Tomb Raider	Rust, Call of Duty, Battlefield	Mobile Legends, Destiny, Gears of War

	Ninja	Bounty Hunter	Architect	Bard	
Motto	*"A Duel of Speed and Skill."*	*"High-Octane Solo World Exploration."*	*"My Empire Begins With This Village."*	*"Playing a Part in a Grand Story."*	
Top Mot.	Competition + Challenge	Destruction + Fantasy	Strategy + Completion	Design + Community + Fantasy	
Pop Games	Street Fighter, StarCraft, LoL	Mass Effect, Far Cry, Saints Row	Europa Universalis, Civ VI, Banished	The Secret World, FFXIV, LoTRO	

Figure 33: **Quantic Foundry Player Segments**

These segments broadly describe a number of player archetypes and help us get a clearer idea of what a potential *Solace* player may look like. Our 3 theoretical player profiles are as follows:

John (Architect / Gardener)

John is primarily an Architect, these players are solo focused and find interest in games that cater to their ability to form and enact plans. As an Architect, John enjoys games that let him take his time, plotting out his moves without any external pressures. John also loves the feeling of building up to something over time, being rewarded by the game through strong progression systems.

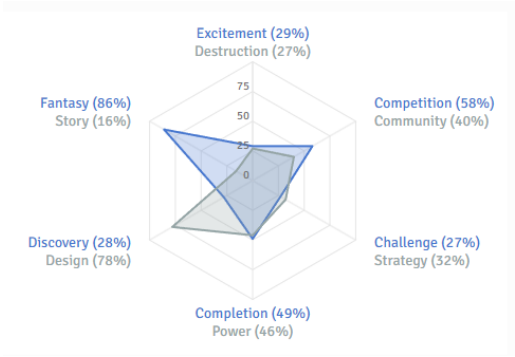

Figure 34: **Architect/Gardner Motivations**

John finds *Solace* to be right up his alley. He really enjoys the way that *Solace* is free of any time sensitive pressures, allowing him to spend as long as he needs to rearrange his tiles every turn. John experiences the most enjoyment while playing as he crafts the perfect tile layout that results in a satisfyingly clean root network and rewards him with meaningful new upgrades.

Gwen (Gardener/Gladiator)

Gwen is primarily a Gardener. This means that Gwen enjoys games that are intuitive and easy to jump into, deriving interest from completing a wide range of tasks such as completing achievements or collecting every collectable a game has to offer. Gwen prefers games that aren't too intense, instead looking for relaxing experiences.

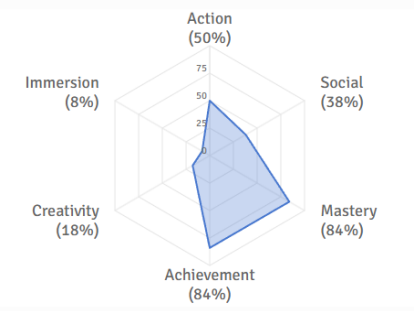

Figure 35: **Gardener/Gladiator Motivations**

Gwen likes the way that *Solace* has a wide range of challenges (achievements) for her to complete, it's one of the main things that keeps her coming back to the game. While chasing the last couple challenges that *Solace* has to offer, Gwen has also come to really enjoy the depth that the games puzzle system has to offer, aiming for higher and higher places on the endless leaderboard as she attempts to complete the game.

Gina (Architect/Bounty Hunter)

Gina is also primarily an Architect, a player interested in planning and progression however her secondary segment it that of a bounty hunter, players who want to immerse themselves in a world and customise it to their liking

Gina loves the way that *Solace* makes her feel like she's creating her own little world. She has recently been focused on collecting every unlockable colour palette so that she can further customise the world to her liking. Gina isn't really interested in getting high scores using the endless game mode and instead just prefers to play the regular golden seed mode, completing challenges as she goes.

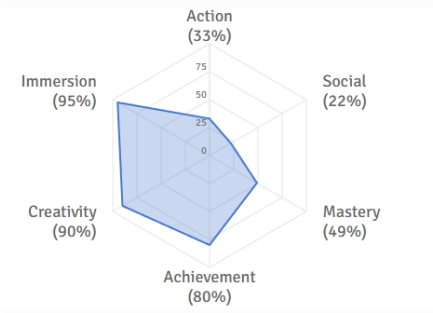

Figure 36: **Architect/Bounty Hunter Mot.**

Comparator Title Analysis

Comparator definition: A title that is above what we're looking for in terms of success (not a competitor) but can be used as a comparison for the purpose of analysis

The target market for *Solace* is players who already enjoy games with tags such as 'turn-based strategy', 'city-builder', 'puzzle', 'relaxing', 'simulation', 'strategy', and 'minimalist'. These players have likely played or at least heard of our key market comparator games;

- *Dorfromantik (Toukana Interactive, 2021)*
- Mini Motorways (*Dinosaur Polo Club, 2019)*
- Terra Nil (*Free Lives,* 2023)

We can use these comparator titles to get a greater understanding of what our target audience actually looks like and as such lets us make design and marketing decisions with stronger standing

Gender Distribution & Demographics

Another lens we may use to analyse our target audience is their gender distribution. Note that we understand gender is a very wide spectrum and does not strictly denote a players interests, we do however believe it can be useful in determining some wider trends, potential genre demographics and play patterns.

To draw out data about our comparator titles target market and audience, we will draw on audience data taken from visitors to each of these titles' website domains. All the following data has been taken from the competitor research website semrush.com.

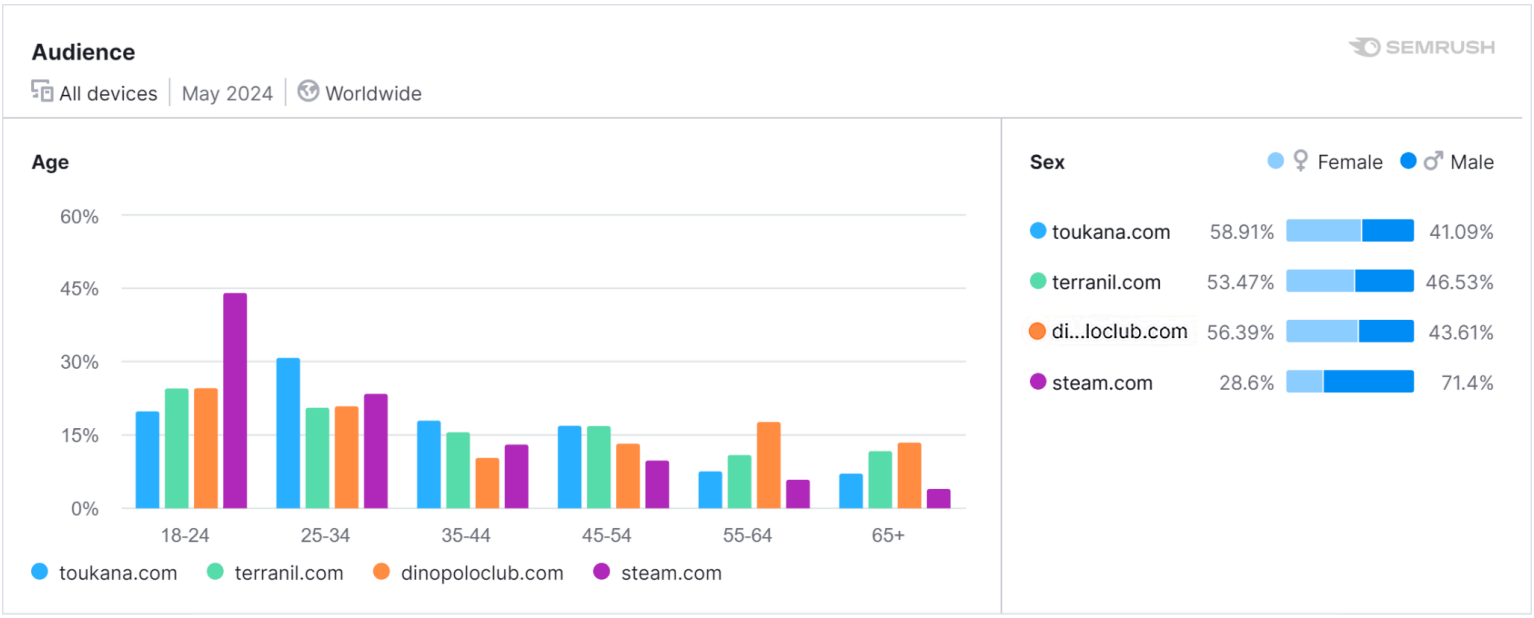

Figure 37: **Comparator Audience Demographics**

This graph shows us a breakdown of both the age and gender of the people who visited our comparators websites during May 2024 along with steam data to give us something to measure against.

This graph gives us an idea of the kind of demographics we may expect from *Solace*. To start with we can look at the steam distribution and as expected it's fairly male-dominated however when focusing more specifically on our comparators we can see this distribution start to shift to more equal footing.

The fact that the overall audience of games is heavily skewed towards males but the specific audience of these cosy strategy games still shows a strong female audience is an indicator and can be used to more effectively target our marketing and design strategies

Gender Play Patterns

We must understand that as a result of our design and aesthetics we are likely to have a more balanced target audience in terms of gender than some other titles (highly conflict focused games for example). It's also important to know how that affects our design and approach to creating *Solace* as a whole. A report (*Dębek, M, Cieślak, K. (2021, 15 10). REPORT: Women and games – how do modern female gamers play?*) by TryEvidence on how gender influences play patterns may give us some more insight into play patterns, favoured genres and more.

This graph to the right begins to give us an idea of what kind of genres may broadly appeal across male and female gamers. The important thing to note from this graph for *Solace* is where these interests overlap. For example we see encouraging strong overlap in the relevant genres of:

- City Builders
- Logic and puzzles
- Simulation

This next graph describes what kinds of game dynamics this particular sample of gamers find most enjoyable in their games split by gender. Again, we're looking for strong overlaps here as we've seen that *Solace* is likely to target a diverse group.

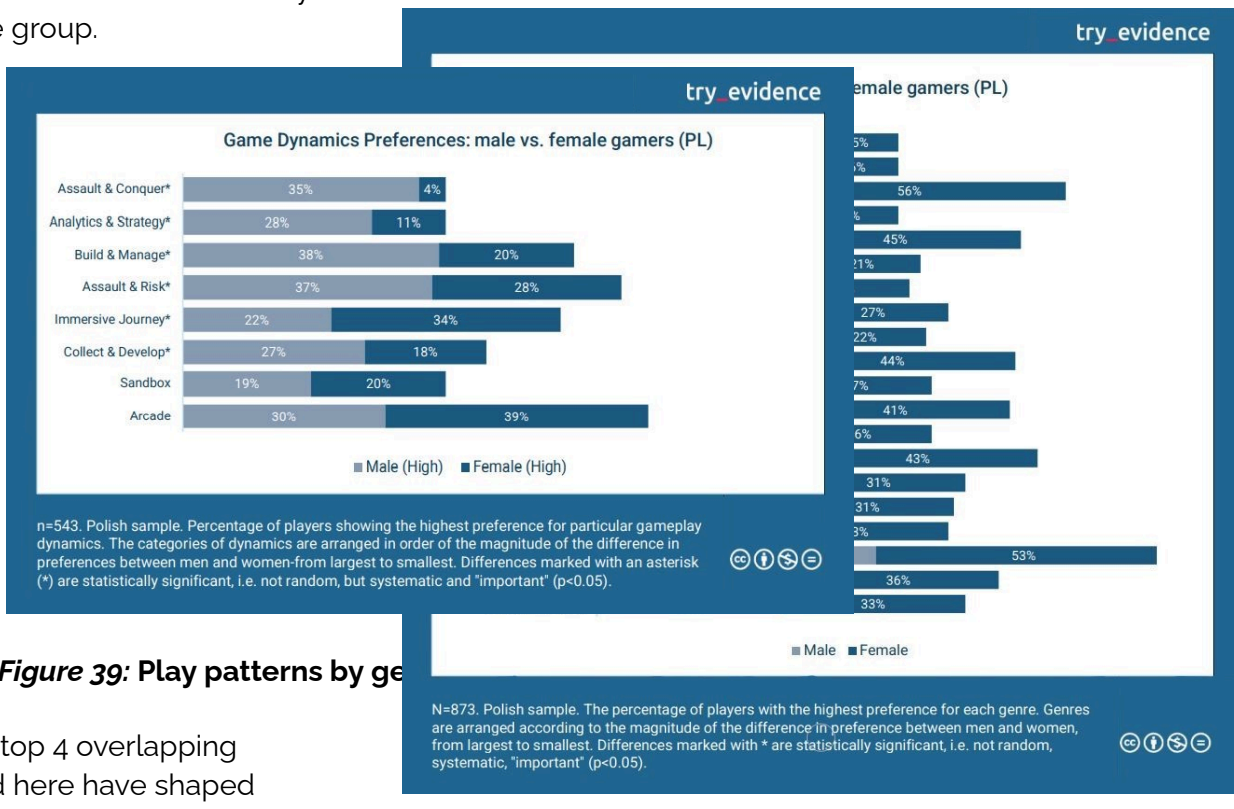

Figure 39: **Play patterns by ge**

Figure 38: **Genre preference by gender**

Here's how the top 4 overlapping dynamics listed here have shaped *Solace*'s development;

- Immersive Journey
    - *Solace* has prioritised immersion of the player at every step of development. We have been crafting an experience that allows players to be fully focused on the world they create, opting for things like diegetic UI and strong physicality in our controls to further this along with putting a heavy focus on creating a powerful visual identity for our players to get invested in. We believe *Solace* will fulfil this gameplay dynamic very effectively.
- Sandbox
    - *Solace*'s design allows for strong player agency; we do not punish a player for approaching the game in a specific way. This is reflected strongly in our tiles not having a lock functionality when placed, most games in this genre will lock the players decisions turn by turn removing most of that Sandbox feeling. The team continues to investigate possible game modes for *Solace* but we know that the game's free flowing mechanics and immersive art lend itself very well to this game dynamic and we will approach new modes with that in mind.
- Arcade
    - Arcade games are light, fun and addictive. An important part of *Solace's* design has been that it remains approachable and intuitive while balancing the more cerebral puzzle elements. In keeping with this strongly liked game dynamic the team has endeavoured to keep play sessions short and punchy, aiming to give the game a “one more run” game loop that allows players to drop in and out whenever they wish.
- Build & Manage
    - The fact that *Solace* is all about building and managing a new world for the Nomes should resonate very well with our target demographic

Social Media Use

We can also leverage our comparator analysis to solidify our assumptions about how our target audience uses social media. Considering a target age range of 25-34 we can interpret the following graph.

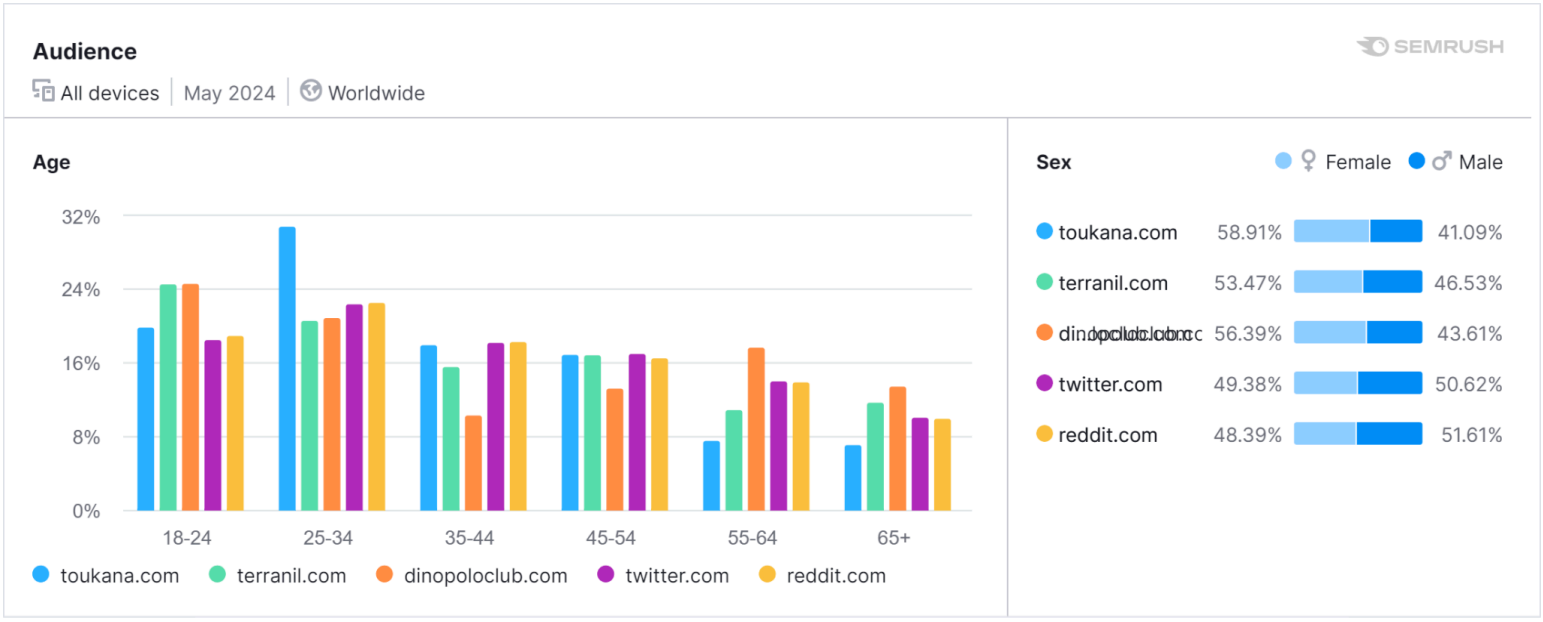

Figure 40: **Target audience social media usage**

Here we can see a graph displaying the overlap between our comparator titles and two of our proposed social media options. This graph has limited utility as the whole of X and Reddit are home to many segmented groups so it's hard to verify if the specific groups we're looking at targeting will line up with this overall graph, however it does give us an idea of the general age and gender distributions nonetheless.

This graph shows us a promising overlap of all the included sets of data around the 25-34 mark, interest in X, Reddit and Dorfromantik peaks within this age range and the other two comparator titles aren't far behind. This tells us that we're likely to find our target demographic when marketing on these platforms especially when targeted more intentionally within Reddit and X.

Demographics

As demonstrated in the previous section, our target demographic are casual to mid-core gamers, aged 25-34, who enjoy quick sessions of gameplay, immersive worlds and lightweight arcade experiences. This audience enjoys cute, pleasing, relaxing games that don't stress their players and instead aim to give them a respite after a long day. The audience skews more towards women in relation to the general Steam demographics (largely skewed male overall) as the game contains a lot of themes/genres that better resonate with a diverse audience with a fairly balanced ratio of male and female players. Our target demographic enjoy cosy low-stress sandbox games which reward more strategic play as their experience grows.

Marketing

Solace's marketing campaign will focus heavily on influencers who specialise in "cosy" style games. The cosy community, especially on places like Tiktok and Instagram are extremely active and there are creators who specialise specifically in cosy game recommendations. The team will aim to introduce *Solace* into this community as it's a wonderful fit for the game's warm aesthetics and low-stakes design.

Influencer List

As mentioned above we'll be looking to find cosy games influencers particularly on Tiktok and Instagram who are interested in talking about *Solace* on their channels. We've begun collating a list of possible compatible influencers here

Initial investigations here have been encouraging with a number of popular creators exclusively focused on creating cosy gaming content and recommending titles to players. Something additional to note here is that these communities seem to have a large amount of buy-in to the Nintendo Switch. The team is interested in catering to this interest with a switch port of *Solace* given success of the steam release.

Social Media Marketing Strategy

Along with targeted influencer campaigns, we'll look at targeting specific communities on places like X and Reddit as well as other social media channels, posting regular updates and creating a community consisting of interested players who can then be gathered in a dedicated *Solace* Discord.

Popular avenues for indie marketing include places such as r/gaming, r/gamedev, #screenshotsaturday, #gamedev, #indiedev, #UnrealEngine but marketing will additionally target smaller, more focused communities like r/basebuildinggames and r/CozyGamers. When the time comes for specific updates or releases, this community can be mobilised to create more buzz around the game ensuring more visibility to people outside of the community. Prior experience with this process gained in the development of Mythos Party will be invaluable in this community-building.

Community building also helps to support analysis and predictions around the game's chances of success when communicating with potential publishers.

Why Fund Us?

Powerful Theme

We are strongly confident that *Solace's* theme and narrative will resonate with players. In most similar games, the player is an amorphous entity, placing blocks with no grounding in reality and no clear goals. While this isn't necessarily negative, there is room for a more themed approach. The Nomes give *Solace* character and a memorable narrative around which to shape gameplay along with helping to create a unique setting that meshes both spacefaring and woodland themes in ways not seen before within the genre.

Image 41: Early Nome character development sketch

Familiar Mechanics With A Healthy Dose Of Innovation

Solace has a set of game mechanics which are recognisable to players while maintaining points of difference. Players who are used to the *Dorfromantik* style game loop will find much of what they loved present here with enough mechanical changes to dig their teeth into. Game mechanics have been designed via a thorough prototyping process that has shown the gameplay to be deeply rewarding for players.

Go To Market

There has been an upsurge in interest in cosy-strategic games with low barriers to entry that leave room for players to breathe. *Solace* has the intuitive interactions, cosy aesthetic, and puzzle-solving gameplay needed to bridge the gap for players looking for something new in this space. *Solace* also offers something thematically and strategically fresh to attract players with a range of previous game experience. The target audience is not attracted by combat-heavy, competitive, or stressful experiences. *Solace* is created for players who want something different.

The Team

This team is perfectly situated to deliver *Solace*.

The art team have extensive experience in game-performant asset creation and developing unique expressive styles for games. This gives them the skills and confidence to craft a

standout visual identity for the game and to create a seamless player experience across UI, narrative, world-building, and gameplay.

We have an extremely experienced lead developer on this project with 15 years in the games industry and many titles under his belt, *Solace*'s development will be in safe hands.

The design for Solace is being led by a senior designer with plentiful experience developing punchy prototypes with intuitive interfaces.

The team of experienced multidisciplinary industry professionals can be trusted to follow through on the vision, able to predict issues before they arise and respond to any changes as required while remaining flexible.

Scope

Games can be highly complex, and any change that occurs during game development can significantly increase scope. *Solace* has been designed specifically with the aim to maximise replayability and depth while maintaining a small scope through an intentionally system-driven design. Development progresses through systems rather than through a constant flow of new curated content, allowing any work the team does to stretch further and in turn, lower overall scope.

Demo

Attached with this application is a build of *Solace* that heavily focuses on the base mechanics of the game. This build contains many of the core mechanics of *Solace* and should give you a feel for the puzzle; the current build contains placeholder art, additional supporting mechanics and minimal gameplay communication with no FTUE.

Missing from this demo:

- Art (except placeholders)
- Places of Power feature
- A substantial game mode
- Store and Shop
- FTUE

How To Play

- Interact with tiles by clicking and dragging them
- To complete a turn you must first drag out two of the four potential tiles from the World Tree and then click the glowing yellow button to confirm your choice
- Tiles may be placed back if you change your mind
- Tiles can be rotated with mouse wheel up, WASD to move the camera
- Scroll wheel down to zoom out (when not hovering a tile)

- Your current score is shown above the end turn button in the middle of your World Tree.
- You will have 10 turns to generate as much energy as possible.
- Consult the gameplay section if anything else is unclear

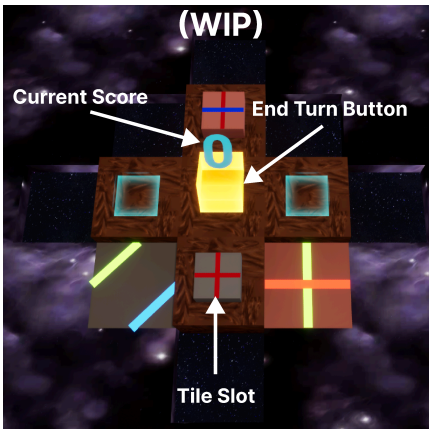

Image 42: **Turn flow helper image**